THE SENIOR DOG

Understanding and supporting your aging companion

A practical guide to understanding, supporting
and protecting the well-being of your senior dog

Lauréna Haroy
Dog and Cat Behaviorist

About This Guide

Your dog is getting older, and the way you care for them needs to change too.

This guide brings together what's worth knowing as your companion enters old age: the physical, sensory, and emotional changes they go through, the problems that may arise, and above all, the practical adjustments that will help them live through this stage with as much comfort and peace of mind as possible.

Each chapter can be read on its own, depending on what you're going through with your dog right now. Feel free to come back to it over time: a senior dog's needs change, sometimes quickly.

> *This guide is meant to inform and support you. It is in no way a substitute for veterinary advice, which is essential to rule out any medical cause and tailor your dog's care.*

CONTENTS

Chapter 1 — Understanding How Your Dog Ages....4
Chapter 2 — Involutional Depression....6
Chapter 3 — Cognitive Dysfunction Syndrome....8
Chapter 4 — Sensory Loss....10
Chapter 5 — Sleep Problems....12
Chapter 6 — Adapting the Everyday Environment....14
Chapter 7 — Motivation and Stimulation: No-Fail Games and Enrichment....16
Chapter 8 — Going Through This Stage with Peace of Mind....18

Chapter 1 — Understanding How Your Dog Ages

Aging isn't a disease. It's a natural stage in your dog's life, just like growing up or reaching puberty. It does, however, bring gradual changes that are worth knowing about, so you can see them coming instead of discovering them with worry.

The age at which a dog becomes a "senior" varies a great deal with size and breed: a small dog is often considered old from 10–12 years, while a large-breed dog may be considered senior as early as 6–7. So it isn't a universal number, but a gradual transition that's different for every dog.

Physical Changes

Your dog may move more slowly and have more trouble climbing stairs, jumping into the car, or getting up after a nap. Their joints, muscles, and overall stamina change, sometimes gradually, sometimes noticeably within a few months.

Their coat may turn gray, especially around the muzzle, and their skin may become thinner and more sensitive.

Pain: A Common Cause of Irritability

Pain from arthritis, joint problems, or other physical discomfort is a common cause of behavior changes in older dogs, particularly irritability or sharper reactions than usual: growling when handled, not wanting to be touched in certain places, unusual aggression toward other pets in the household, or avoiding certain movements. This isn't a lack of patience or a personality problem. It's often the only way a dog can tell you they're in pain. A veterinary checkup can identify and relieve that pain, and behavior very often improves significantly as a result.

Sensory Changes

Sight and hearing often decline gradually. A dog who no longer responds when called, startles when touched without seeing you coming, or seems hesitant in dim light isn't necessarily indifferent or grumpy: they simply perceive their surroundings less well.

Sensory changes are covered in more detail in Chapter 4.

Cognitive and Emotional Changes

The brain ages too. Some dogs become more anxious and more dependent on their owners, while others withdraw. Others may show true disorientation, a more specific condition called cognitive dysfunction syndrome (Chapter 3).

It's important to keep in mind one simple principle that runs through this entire guide:

> *Your dog doesn't change their behavior out of spite, stubbornness, or lack of affection. Every change has a cause (physical, sensory, or emotional) that can be identified and, in most cases, managed.*

Why Seeing the Vet Early Makes All the Difference

Many owners wait until the signs become very obvious before seeing the vet, thinking that "there's no point putting an old dog through that" or that these changes are simply inevitable. Yet the opposite is

true: the earlier a problem is spotted, the more effective the adjustments (medical or behavioral) will be, and the more they can slow its progression.

The following chapters cover the main problems seen in older dogs, along with practical protocols to support your dog as well as possible in daily life.

Chapter 2 — Involutional Depression

What Is Involutional Depression?

Involutional depression is a condition that can develop in older dogs and is directly linked to aging.

As they age, some dogs become more vulnerable: declining physical or sensory abilities can gradually lead to a depressive state and a loss of interest in their surroundings.

Why Does It Happen?

It’s most often linked to aging itself, but it can also be triggered by long-standing, untreated behavior problems, underlying illnesses, or age-related changes in how the brain works.

The Most Common Behaviors

Your dog may, for example:

- sleep more, or have trouble sleeping;
- seem disoriented;
- forget some of what they’ve learned;
- have accidents in the house;
- play less;
- lose their appetite or, on the contrary, eat more;
- become more anxious;
- become overly attached to their owner.

Not every dog shows all of these symptoms, and their intensity varies greatly from one dog to another.

Behaviors That Can Seem Regressive

It isn’t unusual for an older dog to return to some typical puppy behaviors: constantly seeking contact, needing reassurance or wanting to be carried like a young animal, repeatedly seeking attention, or making excessive demands. This kind of regression usually reflects a greater need for security in the face of the physical, sensory, and emotional changes they’re going through. It isn’t a whim or manipulation, but your dog’s way of looking for comfort.

Grief in Older Dogs

Losing a companion, human or animal, who shared your dog’s daily life can hit hard when a dog is already weakened by age. It can trigger or worsen depression, loss of appetite, low energy, or a stronger need for company. Time, patience, and a stable routine are essential to help them through this period. If the signs persist or get worse, a veterinary or behavioral consultation is recommended.

Separation Anxiety Can Get Worse with Age

A dog who coped well with being alone when younger may become more anxious about it as they age, especially if they lose the sensory or cognitive cues that used to reassure them. This anxiety is different from simple overattachment: it usually comes with more marked signs when the owner is

away (barking or howling, destructive behavior, accidents near doors, restlessness). If these signs appear or intensify in a senior dog, specific behavioral support is available. Feel free to bring it up during a consultation.

Why Does My Dog Act This Way?

Aging can profoundly change how your dog functions, both physically and emotionally.

It's also common for sensory abilities to decline gradually with age. Reduced hearing or eyesight can explain some behavior changes. A dog who no longer responds when called, seems calmer, or startles when touched isn't necessarily becoming indifferent or aggressive: sometimes they're simply perceiving their surroundings less clearly.

That's why a veterinary checkup is essential to assess their health and adapt their care.

What to Avoid

Your dog can't control these age-related changes.

- Don't shut them out because of the inconvenience their behavior may cause (accidents, less energy): it isn't a whim or a lack of training.
- Don't punish them for these changes: punishment does nothing for an age-related condition and only risks adding anxiety to a dog who is already vulnerable.

Goals of the Work

A veterinary consultation comes first, to rule out any medical cause. Depending on the situation, a combination of medical and behavioral care will help improve your dog's quality of life.

On the behavioral side, two approaches are especially helpful: rebuilding motivation through no-fail games (Chapter 7), and adapting their everyday environment (Chapter 6).

In older dogs, stress can also be heightened by age-related pain or physical discomfort (joints, sensory loss, etc.). Natural calming supplements are available and can, in some cases, help reduce this stress day to day. Ask your veterinarian for advice; they can point you toward the solution best suited to your dog's situation.

Key Takeaways

Involutional depression generally can't be cured, since it's linked to aging, but it can be managed to improve your dog's quality of life over the long term.

> *A dog who can't be "cured" can still be cared for: the goal isn't to make age disappear, but to help your dog live through this stage as comfortably as possible.*

Chapter 3 — Cognitive Dysfunction Syndrome

What Is Cognitive Dysfunction Syndrome?

Cognitive dysfunction syndrome, sometimes called canine dementia or cognitive decline in older dogs, is a condition linked to the aging of the brain.

It differs from involutional depression: while depression mainly affects mood and motivation, cognitive dysfunction primarily affects orientation, memory, and understanding of the environment. Your dog can still interact socially, but may seem lost or disoriented, or react in ways that no longer quite fit the situation.

Both conditions can occur in the same dog, which makes a full checkup all the more useful to tell them apart.

Why Does It Happen?

It’s linked to the natural aging of the brain, which can gradually impair certain cognitive functions, broadly similar to what we see in aging humans.

As with involutional depression, a veterinary checkup is essential, because other medical causes (pain, hormonal disorders, neurological or sensory problems) can produce very similar symptoms.

The Most Common Behaviors

Your dog may, for example:

- seem disoriented in places that are nonetheless familiar (getting stuck in a corner, looking for the door in the wrong place);
- reverse their sleep cycle (sleeping during the day, being active or restless at night);
- forget some of what they’ve learned, including house training;
- at times seem not to recognize their surroundings or family members;
- wander aimlessly, or freeze for no apparent reason;
- bark, whine, or howl with no obvious trigger, especially at night;
- interact less spontaneously, or less predictably than before.

Not every dog shows all of these signs, and their intensity varies widely from one dog to another. Some show only one or two subtle signs for a long time.

Why Does My Dog Act This Way?

Your dog isn’t doing it on purpose and isn’t aware of it.

Their brain processes information from their surroundings less effectively, which explains this apparent loss of bearings. It isn’t a lack of affection, nor a behavior problem in the usual sense: it’s a neurological condition, much like memory problems in an elderly person.

Goals of the Work

A veterinary checkup comes first, to assess the cause of the problem and discuss any appropriate medical support.

On the behavioral side, the goal is to adapt your dog's environment and daily routine to limit disorientation and keep them as comfortable as possible. See Chapter 6 for practical adjustments, and Chapter 5 if sleep problems are the main concern.

Key Takeaways

Cognitive dysfunction syndrome can't be cured, but the right support (medical and environmental) can often slow its progression and noticeably improve your dog's quality of life.

The earlier it's spotted and managed, the more effective the adjustments will be.

Chapter 4 — Sensory Loss

What Is Age-Related Sensory Loss?

As in humans, your dog's sight and hearing may gradually decline with age. This decline is usually slow and partial: most dogs adapt remarkably well, as long as the people around them take it into account.

It's often this sensory decline, more than any other factor, that explains behavior changes that would otherwise be hard to understand.

How to Recognize Hearing Loss

Your dog may, for example:

- stop responding when you call, especially from a distance or from behind;
- startle more when touched without seeing the person coming;
- sleep more deeply than before, without waking at familiar sounds;
- bark differently, sometimes louder, because they can't hear themselves as well.

How to Recognize Vision Loss

Your dog may, for example:

- hesitate or bump into things in dim light, when they used to get around without any trouble;
- be more cautious on stairs or unfamiliar surfaces;
- startle more at sudden movements they can no longer anticipate as well;
- prefer familiar surroundings and be more reluctant to explore new places.

Why Does My Dog Act This Way?

A dog who perceives their surroundings less well may seem indifferent, aggressive, or anxious, when most of the time they're just reacting to an incomplete or delayed perception of what's around them.

> *Startling and growling when touched by surprise isn't a lack of tolerance: it's often the normal reaction of a dog who simply didn't see or hear the hand coming.*

A veterinary checkup can determine exactly how much sensory loss there is and rule out a treatable cause (cataracts or an ear infection, for example).

How to Adapt Daily Life

- Always approach your dog from the front, or make some noise as you come near, so you never take them by surprise.
- Pair your presence with a touch signal (a light tap on the side), so they learn to associate it with you rather than with a threat.
- Keep their surroundings the same: same furniture, same places, so they can keep finding their way by memory rather than by sight.

- If their hearing declines, gradually teach hand signals so you can keep communicating with them at a distance.
- If their eyesight is failing, avoid dark or poorly lit areas in the evening; a soft night-light can make a big difference.

Fear of Vet Visits

An older dog who is more sensitive to handling and sometimes in pain may become increasingly anxious about going to the vet, which can unfortunately delay much-needed appointments. A few simple habits can help reduce this stress:

- Make frequent “social visits” to the clinic, with no treatment, just a friendly welcome and a treat;
- Gradually get them used to being handled calmly at home (paws, ears, mouth), pairing it with something pleasant;
- Whenever possible, stick with the same veterinarian, in a setting they know;
- Stay calm yourself during the appointment: your dog picks up on your own anxiety.

If the anxiety remains strong despite these habits, talk to your veterinarian or behaviorist: there are ways to make these visits less stressful, even for the most reluctant dogs.

Key Takeaways

Sensory loss is a natural change that is rarely reversible, but dogs compensate remarkably well when the people around them adjust a few simple habits.

Chapter 6 covers in more detail all the ways to adapt the environment for a senior dog, whether or not sensory loss is involved.

Chapter 5 — Sleep Problems

Why Does Sleep Get Disrupted with Age?

In older dogs, cognitive decline or certain physical discomforts can disrupt their sense of day and night. Your dog may then become active and restless or vocalize at night, while sleeping a lot during the day: a true reversal of their usual cycle.

A veterinary checkup comes first, to rule out any medical cause (pain, a need to urinate more often, hormonal disorders) that could explain these nighttime awakenings before considering behavioral work.

Recognizing a Reversed Day-Night Cycle

Your dog may, for example:

- sleep much longer than usual during the day;
- become restless, pace, or vocalize at night;
- wake the family at unusual hours;
- seem disoriented on waking, especially at night.

Step-by-Step Protocol

1. More Stimulation During the Day

Offer walks, calm games, and sniffing activities (see Chapter 7) to limit long naps during the day. A dog who uses a bit more mental and physical energy during the day generally sleeps better at night.

2. Adjust the Evening Routine

Take them out one last time late in the evening, just before bedtime, to reduce the need to urinate during the night. Keep a stable, predictable bedtime routine at a regular time: consistency is reassuring for a dog whose internal clock is weakening.

3. Limit Stimulation in the Evening

Dim the lights and reduce noise in the evening to help them fall asleep. A calm atmosphere at the end of the day sends your dog a clear message: it will soon be time to sleep.

4. Respond Calmly to Nighttime Awakenings

If your dog wakes up at night, avoid stimulating them further (play, bright light, long interactions): stay neutral and calm so you don’t unintentionally reinforce this new waking pattern. A soft night-light can help a dog who is disoriented in the dark find their bearings without waking up completely.

Mistakes to Avoid

- Skipping the veterinary checkup: a medical cause must always be ruled out first.
- Stimulating your dog during nighttime awakenings, even out of affection: this can reinforce the new pattern.
- Letting daytime naps get longer without offering activities during the day.
- Changing all their sleep habits abruptly at once.

What to Expect

Improvement is usually gradual and takes several weeks of consistency. In some dogs, a complete recovery isn’t always possible, but a noticeable reduction in nighttime awakenings often is.

> *A consistent daily routine (meals, walks, activities, bedtime) is the most effective way to help your dog regain a steadier sense of time.*

Chapter 6 — Adapting the Everyday Environment

Why Adapt Their Environment?

As they age, your dog may see, hear, or move less well than before. An environment that hasn't changed becomes harder to navigate, which can lead to stress, disorientation, or minor accidents.

Adapting their living space doesn't mean turning everything upside down. On the contrary, it means strengthening the stability and predictability they now need more than ever.

Key Adjustments

Familiar Landmarks

As much as possible, keep furniture, bowls, and their bed in the same place: a stable environment is reassuring for a dog whose bearings, sensory or cognitive, are weakening.

Mobility

Make it easier for them to get around with non-slip rugs on slippery floors, and steps or ramps to reach the couch or get into the car. A soft night-light helps a dog with poor eyesight find their way in the dark.

Comfortable Rest

Provide a comfortable, soft, easy-to-reach bed, out of the main traffic areas but not too isolated if your dog is becoming more sensitive to being alone or more anxious.

Access to Essentials

Set up several easy-to-reach water and food stations if their mobility is reduced, especially if they live on more than one floor.

Routine

Keep regular times for meals and walks. Take them out more often, for shorter distances, rather than cutting back on walks: this keeps them in touch with the world around them without straining them physically.

Diet

Diet is an important pillar of an older dog's well-being, but it needs to be adjusted with care. A fairly common misconception is that you should increase protein to "support" an aging dog, when the opposite is often recommended: in a senior dog, especially if kidney function is starting to decline (which is common with age), too much protein can put even more strain on the kidneys.

An older dog's nutritional needs are specific and change with their health: you can't guess them, and they shouldn't be adjusted at random or based on popular beliefs. Only your veterinarian can accurately assess your dog's needs, in particular through blood work, and guide you toward a diet that truly suits their situation.

Hot Weather

Older dogs often tolerate heat less well than younger ones: their ability to regulate body temperature decreases, and some heart, joint, or respiratory problems can get worse in hot weather. A few simple precautions will help them get through the summer:

- Walk them early in the morning or in the evening, avoiding the hottest hours of the day;
- Make sure they always have access to fresh water, with several water bowls around the house;
- Give them a cool, shaded place to rest, possibly with a cooling mat;
- Avoid any strenuous exercise during heat waves;
- Never leave them alone in a car, even for a few minutes, even in the shade.

An older dog who pants excessively, seems listless, or refuses to move in hot weather should be cooled down gradually (with lukewarm water, never ice-cold) and seen by a veterinarian immediately if the signs don't improve quickly.

Living with a Puppy or an Energetic Child

A new puppy full of energy, or a young child who constantly seeks attention, can be a heavy load for an older dog who needs more calm and rest. A few adjustments can help everyone live together peacefully:

- Always provide a safe space that only your senior dog can access, where they can retreat without being disturbed;
- Supervise interactions, especially with a very playful puppy or a young child, to avoid overwhelming them;
- Respect their rest time: an older dog who withdraws isn't sulking, they need to recover;
- Make the most of quiet moments together rather than forcing interaction.

An older dog who shows signs of irritability toward a puppy or a child isn't just "grumpy": it's often a sign that they need more space or rest. See also Chapter 1 on pain, a common cause of this kind of reaction.

Mistakes to Avoid

- Frequently rearranging your home: this makes things more confusing for a dog who relies on familiar landmarks.
- Drastically cutting back on walks for fear of tiring them out: shorter but more frequent walks are better.
- Neglecting small comfort adjustments in the belief that they're only useful once a problem has already appeared.

What to Expect

These adjustments won't reverse aging, but they often significantly reduce your dog's stress and daily difficulties, with benefits that show quickly in most cases.

Every small adjustment counts: there's no need to change everything at once. Introduce changes gradually, watching for what helps your dog the most.

Chapter 7 — Motivation and Stimulation: No-Fail Games and Enrichment

Why Does Motivation Drop with Age?

A dog who has had many negative experiences, who is old, or who is going through a period of depression or confusion often tends to generalize these negative experiences: they lose confidence, shut down, and gradually withdraw from interaction and learning.

Two complementary approaches can rebuild their motivation for the long term: no-fail game therapy and enriching their everyday environment.

No-Fail Game Therapy

No-fail games use very simple exercises in which the dog is sure to succeed, to rebuild their motivation and interest in learning. Unlike a standard exercise, the difficulty is deliberately kept very low: the goal is never to test their abilities, but to let them string together successes and rewards.

Very Simple Exercises

- finding a ball placed a few yards away;
- finding a treat hidden in one of your two hands;
- finding a treat under a piece of paper or cloth.

Each success earns an immediate, enthusiastic reward. Once their confidence is back, you can gradually move on to other small activities: finding the front door, exploring the yard again, or any other simple game your dog enjoys.

This therapy is also valuable for reviving your relationship, which may have faded as your dog grew older or less responsive.

Enrichment for Senior Dogs

Environmental enrichment means offering your dog a variety of physical, mental, and sensory activities suited to their current abilities rather than to the ones they had when they were younger.

- easy sniffing games: hide a few treats within easy reach of their nose, with no excessive physical effort;
- suitable snuffle mats or puzzle bowls, which turn mealtime into gentle mental exercise;
- “sniff walks,” where you let them explore and smell at their own pace instead of setting a brisk walking pace;
- regularly rotating simple toys to keep things new without setting them up to fail;
- short, frequent sessions rather than long, tiring ones.

Mistakes to Avoid

- Offering an exercise that’s too hard: the dog must win every single time, without exception.
- Using a reward that doesn’t really motivate them.
- Doing too many exercises in a row: short, frequent sessions are better.

- Focusing only on physical exercise and forgetting mental stimulation, which is just as important at this age.
- Getting discouraged if progress seems slow: it’s confidence that is being rebuilt first and foremost, not performance.

What to Expect

The first sessions are often the hardest: a dog who has shut down may need a little time before fully engaging in the game again.

> *Progress usually shows up as a gradual return of interest, enthusiasm, and initiative: subtle signs, but ones that reflect real renewed confidence.*

What matters most in this work is that your dog rediscovers the joy of succeeding and being rewarded. Every small win counts: together, they gradually rebuild their motivation and the trust between you.

Chapter 8 — Going Through This Stage with Peace of Mind

A Chapter for You, Too

Caring for an aging dog isn't always easy emotionally. Watching your companion slow down, lose their bearings, or become more fragile can stir up worry and sadness, sometimes even a kind of anticipatory grief. That's normal, and you're not alone in feeling this way.

Taking care of yourself during this stage is also part of caring for your dog: ask those around you for support, and don't hesitate to talk to your veterinarian or behaviorist if the emotional weight becomes hard to carry alone.

When to See the Vet

Some signs call for a prompt visit to the vet, beyond routine checkups:

- a sudden rather than gradual change in behavior;
- a marked loss of appetite or weight loss;
- signs of pain (limping, reluctance to move, whimpering);
- disorientation or confusion that gets worse quickly;
- any change that worries you, even if you can't quite put your finger on it.

Some Examples of Signs Not to Ignore

Some changes can have several causes, both behavioral and medical, and only a veterinary exam can tell the difference. For example:

- drinking or urinating much more than usual: this may point to stress, but also to kidney problems, diabetes, or other medical causes;
- loss of appetite or, on the contrary, excessive hunger: this may have a behavioral cause (involutional depression) or a medical one (pain, a digestive or hormonal disorder);
- unusual tiredness or lack of energy: this may be part of normal aging, but also a sign of joint pain, a heart problem, or something else;
- frequent barking, whining, or restlessness at night: this may be linked to cognitive dysfunction syndrome (Chapter 3), but also to pain that hasn't been identified;
- new house-soiling: this may be behavioral (Chapters 2 and 3) or a sign of a urinary, digestive, or hormonal problem.

In all these cases, the right reflex is the same: see your veterinarian first, to rule out or confirm a medical cause before considering behavioral support.

When in doubt, it's always better to see the vet: most of the problems covered in this guide benefit from early care, and a professional can rule out an underlying medical cause that this guide, by its very nature, can neither diagnose nor treat.

Assessing Day-to-Day Quality of Life

At a very advanced age, or with a chronic illness, a difficult question may come up: how do I know if my dog still has a good quality of life? There's no single answer or fixed checklist, but a few simple points can help you look at their daily life a little more clearly:

- Do they still eat and drink with at least some interest?
- Do they still have moments of pleasure: being petted, an interesting smell, a patch of sunshine, a short walk?
- Does their pain seem well controlled day to day?
- Can they still get up, move around, and relieve themselves without too much discomfort?
- Do their good moments still outnumber the bad ones?

These points don't replace medical advice: they're there to help you put into words what you observe day to day before talking it over with your veterinarian. This reflection should be shared: you, who know your dog better than anyone, and your veterinarian, for the medical side.

If this reflection leads you to consider end-of-life care, know that your veterinarian is the best person to guide you through this decision, with all the compassion this moment deserves. You are never alone with this question, however difficult it may be.

A New Stage, Not the End

Your dog's old age doesn't erase everything you've built together. It's a new stage in your relationship, with its own adjustments, not the end of your bond.

> *Many senior dogs, with the right support, continue to enjoy their daily lives to the fullest: shorter walks that are still shared, simpler games that bring you just as close, and a presence that matters at any age.*

This guide isn't meant to replace personalized follow-up. Every dog ages in their own way, at their own pace, and with their own needs. If you have any questions or would like support tailored to your dog's specific situation, feel free to contact me for a consultation.

This guide is meant to inform and support you; it is not a substitute for veterinary advice if you suspect a medical cause.